

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

8

How to Overcome the Curse of Competence

Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.

Do You Have a Learning Disorder?

Sir Ken Robinson was a British author, speaker, and international advisor on education, renowned for his TED Talk “Do Schools Kill Creativity?”, which has been viewed over 100 million times. Separately, he has shared a story about a girl named Gillian who was eight years old when her school wrote to her parents complaining about her poor academic performance and disruptive classroom behavior. They said she had a high-risk future and suggested she might have a learning disorder requiring her to attend a different school. This worried her parents, so they spoke to a psychologist.

During the consultation, Gillian felt uneasy, knowing the psychologist’s evaluation could significantly impact her future. At one point, the psychologist left Gillian alone in a room with the radio on. Gillian danced around the room, displaying incredible grace and immense skill. It was clear she was a gifted dancer. After just a few minutes of being transfixed by this dancing, the psychologist turned to Gillian’s mother and said to

her, “Your daughter doesn’t have a learning disorder. She’s a dancer. Take her to a dance school.”

That’s exactly what Gillian’s mother did. Gillian auditioned for the Royal Ballet School in London, and to her delight, they accepted her. She discovered a whole group of people who, in her own words, “had to move to think.” Gillian then went on to form her own musical production company. She collaborated with Andrew Lloyd Webber and created performances that brought joy to countless audiences around the world. Gillian Lynne, the eight-year-old with a high-risk future, became one of the most successful choreographers ever. She performed for millions, made millions of dollars, and lived a fulfilling life until her death at the remarkable age of ninety-two.

Now, imagine if Gillian hadn’t visited a psychologist who recognized that her academic struggles did not make her broken, but simply made her different. Imagine if her mother had simply said, “Oh well, the school must be right. We’ll send her to a different school.” Imagine if Gillian were told nothing more than to calm down and stop causing trouble. Gillian was lucky she met an insightful psychologist who guided her in the right direction. This chapter is your opportunity to have a similar encounter.

Gillian’s story highlights that when we are emotionally engaged in our work, our ability to learn and improve is exponentially higher than when we dread what we do. Gillian’s success exposes the fallacy that intelligence is a function of mental horsepower, a misconception created by the Industrial Revolution’s narrow fixation on literacy and numeracy. Indeed, psychologist Howard Gardner’s Theory of Multiple Intelligences shows that aside from linguistic intelligence (thinking in words and language) and logical-mathematical intelligence (dealing with numbers), there are six additional intelligences that receive far less attention.

1. **How does a sculptor visualize a finished piece before carving the stone?** The sculptor uses *spatial intelligence*, much like sailors visualize their position in the ocean and navigate by the stars. The ability to think in three dimensions is used by sailors, pilots, sculptors, painters, and architects.

2. **How does a surgeon perform delicate operations with precise hand movements and hand-eye coordination?** Surgeons use *kinesthetic intelligence*, much like dancers such as Gillian Lynne, who express themselves through their bodies' movements. The ability to control bodily movements and manipulate the movement of objects is used by athletes, dancers, surgeons, and artists.
3. **How did Ludwig van Beethoven create symphonies that are still celebrated today, despite being almost completely deaf?** Beethoven used *musical intelligence*, much like composers, conductors, and musicians, who discern pitch, rhythm, timbre, and tone.
4. **How does a teacher create a more engaging learning environment?** Teachers use *interpersonal intelligence*, much like actors and leaders, to engage deeply with others.
5. **How did Nelson Mandela maintain his self-awareness, inner strength, and commitment to reconciliation despite spending twenty-seven years in prison?** Mandela used *intrapersonal intelligence*, much like writers, psychologists, and mindfulness teachers, who are in touch with their feelings, fears, and motivations.
6. **How did Charles Darwin develop the Theory of Evolution?** Darwin used *naturalistic intelligence*, much like biologists, veterinarians, and wildlife managers, who appreciate and understand the natural world.

Whoever suggested that Gillian had a learning disorder needed to spend more time learning about the definition of intelligence. Are the most academically qualified professors at the most elite colleges also elite athletes? If not, do they have a kinesthetic learning disorder? Or do they just play to their strengths and ignore their weaknesses?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Shaped by the demands of the Industrial Revolution, the traditional education system has long prioritized literacy and numeracy over other types of intelligence. This bias is structural, not a failure of the many teachers who strive daily to nurture their students' diverse gifts. Yet beyond the classroom, the world applauds those who lean into their unique strengths — dancers, athletes, inventors, creators, and many more — proving that brilliance comes in many forms.

Let's now explore which of these intelligences is your greatest strength.

What Is the True Definition of a Strength?

We're told our strengths are the things we're good at, while our weaknesses are the things we're not good at. Seems obvious, right? Well, it turns out to be wrong. It's not how good you are at an activity that matters. It's how the activity makes you feel. A strength makes you feel stronger. It's an expression of your true self. A weakness makes you feel weaker.

You might be a skilled accountant, but if crunching numbers drains your energy and leaves you feeling depleted, it's a weakness, not a strength. On the other hand, if public speaking energizes and invigorates you, even if you're not the most polished speaker, it's a strength worth pursuing and developing into a valuable skill that could transform your career.

When you engage a weakness, you betray your true self. You're doing something you know you are not meant to be doing. The result is that even if you achieve a positive outcome, it feels flat and meaningless. The whole process robs you of energy.

Of course, sometimes you need to use a weakness to move a project forward. But don't mistake this for your path. Choosing your work is less about becoming well-rounded and more about becoming well-directed.

The key question to ask here is, "How does this activity make me feel? Does this activity give me energy and make me feel stronger? Or does this activity drain my energy and make me feel weaker?"

As you gravitate toward activities that energize you, work no longer feels like strenuous effort you must endure. Instead, it is an inherently rewarding activity that feels exciting. Choose the work that gives you energy.

Why Do You Hesitate to Engage with Your Strengths?

When I studied law/engineering, I remember all too clearly being asked on the first day, “Why did you decide to study law?” and one student responded, “I chose law because I didn’t get into medicine.” He later mentioned that he just wanted to study something that looked impressive. If he couldn’t get into medicine, law was second best. Some parents say, “You can do anything you like with your life, provided it’s law, medicine, or engineering.” If only this were merely comedy and not the reality for many children.

You enter the world endowed with a specific gift to share. But then you are told to “keep your options open” and to choose a secure job at a well-established company. Elite performers, in contrast, focus on one thing, not multiple options. They choose the path that helps them grow the most, even if there is a risk that things won’t work out the first time.

Every time you trade growth for stability, you also enroll in boredom and tedium. Is that a good deal? Worse, you rob the world of the gifts you possess. Don’t shortchange humanity by sitting on the sidelines. Step up. The world cannot wait to hear the music that you have to share.

Psychologist Abraham Maslow has famously said, “A musician must make music, an artist must paint, a poet must write, if he is to be ultimately at peace with himself.” You might be someone different.

A photographer must capture moments.

A journalist must uncover the truth.

A mediator must foster common understanding.

What is it that you must do?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Know that you will not be at peace until you find the work that you came here to do. You are not here to pursue some abstract idea or to impress anyone or to waste your time. No, you were put on this planet to discover your strengths and share them with the world.

You were put on this planet to choose your work.

How grateful are you just for being born into this world? How grateful are you that you can participate in the miracle of consciousness? If you are truly grateful for this incomparable gift, then you are obligated to embrace your natural strengths to offer something of value to the world. If you are truly grateful, you cannot ignore the massive opportunity cost of squandering your time on activities that drain your energy.

So develop your craft. Work at it. Improve it. Reflect on it. Jazz saxophonist John Coltrane was known to practice a single note for ten hours straight to get the tone and volume exactly right. Many marvel at Stephen Curry's seemingly magical ability to shoot hoops, but few appreciate his relentless practice — 300 to 500 shots every single day, including weekends, amounting to roughly 1.9 million shots over fifteen years. Pablo Picasso created over 20,000 paintings, prints, drawings, sculptures, ceramics, and theater sets. Thomas Edison acquired 1,093 United States patents during his eighty-four-year lifetime, equivalent to one patent every two weeks during his working life. You cannot purchase mastery, nor can you rush it. You must put in the work.

But notice how Coltrane and Curry did not simply put in the work. They both also chose highly engaging work. Mixing hard work with your natural strengths creates a potent chemical reaction that makes you unstoppable.

Think about how this applies to you. If you're even mildly successful in a role that doesn't energize you, imagine the exponentially greater success you would experience by intensely focusing on work that invigorates you rather than depletes your energy.

You might decide to become world-class in an endeavor. But then doubt sets in and you hear yourself saying, "Who am I to reach a world-

class level?” On the other hand, you could ask yourself, “Why not?” Often, you doubt yourself because the world overvalues safety and is filled with a pervasive sense of negativity and cynicism. There is no reason you have to engage with this negativity.

There are countless examples of individuals who refused to accept the cynicism around them. For example, standing at just five feet three inches tall, Muggsy Bogues did not appear to be an elite basketball player. But despite his height disadvantage, he had an incredibly successful career spanning over a decade as the shortest player to ever compete in the NBA. Oprah Winfrey was born into poverty in rural Mississippi to a teenage single mother, and she has since gone on to create a billion-dollar media empire. Statistically, Oprah Winfrey and Muggsy Bogues were never meant to be successful. But their work provided them with vast amounts of energy. What are the activities that bring you vast amounts of energy?

The Curse of Competence

- 1. What are three specific activities I do at work that I am good at but don't particularly enjoy?*
- 2. What are three actions I can take to limit my time doing these activities? How can I automate them, delegate them, or eliminate their less important parts?*
- 3. If I could only take one action to limit my time doing these activities, what would it be?*

Duration

Three minutes

By setting boundaries around draining tasks, you create space for work that truly lights you up.

Write a list of these activities. Beside each activity, consider how you can delegate, minimize, or eliminate each item.

Feel free to go over the suggested duration. This reflection is short by design because small, consistent shifts create lasting changes.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

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Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

Contents

	The Key to Making This Book Work for You	xiii
	This is not a book to simply read.	
1	What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?	1
	Why do so many people experience a deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?	
	<i>Pause: The Three-Year Mirror</i>	
2	The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles	17
	How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Gift</i>	
3	Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort	33
	Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and obscuring the true metrics of success.	
	<i>Pause: The Comfort Trap</i>	
4	How Do You Pay the Bills and Still Choose Your Work?	49
	The one hour that changes everything.	
	<i>Pause: The Hour of Possibility</i>	
5	How to Think Independently in a World Obsessed with Conformity	63
	Why does conforming to the herd hamper your personal growth?	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Voice</i>	
6	Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results	79
	The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.	
	<i>Pause: The Rational Trap</i>	
7	Let the Work Choose You	91
	How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Intuitive Path</i>	
8	How to Overcome the Curse of Competence	105
	Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.	
	<i>Pause: The Curse of Competence</i>	

9	You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day	115
	What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?	
	<i>Pause: The Cathedral</i>	
10	Next Steps to a Fulfilling Life	131
	How to capitalize on this pivotal moment.	
	<i>Pause: The One Project</i>	
	Appendices	
1	Action Plan	141
	A roadmap to convert your insights into action.	
2	How Well-Meaning Parents Unknowingly Steer Their Children Away from Fulfilling Work	145
	Understanding the subtle yet powerful influence parents have on career choices.	
3	What Next?	149
	Stay connected and inspired on your path to fulfilling work.	
4	Frequently Asked Questions	151
	Answers to the most common questions about choosing your work.	
5	The Ten Most Important Questions to Help You Choose Your Work	153
	Start with just one question each day.	
6	Financial Planning for Choosing Your Work	157
	Practical financial strategies to help you on your new path.	
7	Summary and Bonus Strategies	159
	A short guide to help you take action.	
	Notes	161
	Index	190

**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat